

Word family: **burst / bursts / burst / bursting**

Base word: burst

Past tense: burst

Past participle: burst

ing form: bursting

Related forms / useful extensions:

* **burst** (v.) — 爆裂；突然衝出；突然開始

* **burst** (n.) — 爆裂；突然的一陣；突發

* **bursting** (adj./participle) — 爆滿的；充滿……的

* **burst into tears**

* **burst into laughter**

* **burst out laughing**

* **burst out crying**

* **burst open**

* **burst through**

* **burst in / burst into a room**

* **burst with pride**

* **burst with excitement**

* **a burst of laughter**

* **a burst of speed**

* **a burst of energy**

* **a burst of applause**

* **a burst of activity**

* **burst someone's bubble**

Part of speech: mainly **verb** and **noun**

Meaning in this passage

> I thought he would **burst into tears**, but instead he just smiled and said, “That's okay, we can build a better one.”

Here, **burst into tears** means:

to suddenly start crying, usually with strong emotion — 突然哭起來；突然放聲大哭

The expression emphasizes that the crying begins **suddenly and strongly**.

中文翻譯：

我原以為他會**突然哭起來 / 放聲大哭**，但他反而只是笑了笑，說：「沒關係，我們可以再造一

座更好的。」

So here:

burst into tears = 突然開始哭；一下子哭了起來

1. **burst (爆裂；爆開) — 爆裂；破裂**

This is the core literal meaning.

Practice 1

> The balloon **burst** with a loud bang.

氣球「砰」的一聲**爆了**。

Practice 2

> One of the pipes **burst** during the cold weather.

寒冷天氣期間，其中一條水管**爆裂了**。

MCQ-ready definition:

burst = 因壓力過大而突然破裂或爆開

2. **burst something — 使某物爆裂；弄破**

Transitive use.

Practice 1

> Be careful not to **burst the balloon**.

小心不要**弄爆氣球**。

Practice 2

> The pressure **burst the pipe**.

壓力令水管**爆裂**。

MCQ-ready definition:

****burst something = 使某物突然破裂或爆開****

3. ****burst open — 突然爆開 / 猛然打開****

Practice 1

> The door ****burst open****.

門突然****猛地打開****。

Practice 2

> The bag ****burst open**** and everything fell out.

袋子突然****爆開****，裏面的東西全掉了出來。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****burst open = 突然猛烈地打開或裂開****

4. ****burst into somewhere — 突然闖入****

Here, the image shifts from physical explosion to sudden forceful movement.

Practice 1

> He ****burst into the room**** without knocking.

他沒有敲門便突然****闖進房間****。

Practice 2

> Two children ****burst into the kitchen**** laughing.

兩個孩子笑着突然****衝進廚房****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****burst into somewhere = 突然、快速而帶衝力地進入某個地方****

5. ****burst in — 突然闖進來****

Practice 1

> She **burst in** while we were talking.

我們正在談話時，她突然**闖了進來**。

Practice 2

> He **burst in** and shouted that there was a fire.

他突然**衝進來**，大喊說失火了。

MCQ-ready definition:

burst in = 突然快速地進入某處，通常帶有急促或打斷別人的感覺

6. **burst through** — 衝破；突然穿過

Practice 1

> The runners **burst through** the doors.

跑手們突然**衝過門口**。

Practice 2

> Sunlight **burst through** the clouds.

陽光突然**穿透雲層**。

MCQ-ready definition:

burst through = 突然有力地穿過某個障礙或空間

7. **burst into tears** — 突然哭起來

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> I thought he would **burst into tears**.

我原以為他會**突然哭起來**。

Practice 2

> She **burst into tears** when she heard the news.

她聽到消息後突然**哭了起來**。

Practice 3

> The child **burst into tears** after falling over.

那個孩子跌倒後突然**放聲大哭**。

MCQ-ready definition:

burst into tears = 因強烈情緒而突然開始哭泣

8. **burst into laughter** — 突然大笑起來

Practice 1

> Everyone **burst into laughter**.

大家突然**大笑起來**。

Practice 2

> She **burst into laughter** when she saw his costume.

她看到他的服裝時突然**笑了起來**。

MCQ-ready definition:

burst into laughter = 突然開始大笑

9. **burst into applause** — 突然熱烈鼓掌

Practice 1

> The audience **burst into applause**.

觀眾突然**熱烈鼓掌**。

Practice 2

> The room **burst into applause** when she finished speaking.

她講完後，全場突然**響起熱烈掌聲**。

MCQ-ready definition:

burst into applause = 一群人突然開始熱烈鼓掌

10. **burst into song** — 突然唱起歌來

Practice 1

> He suddenly **burst into song**.

他突然**唱起歌來**。

Practice 2

> The children **burst into song** on the way home.

孩子們回家途中突然**一起唱起歌來**。

MCQ-ready definition:

burst into song = 突然開始唱歌

11. **burst out laughing** — 突然笑出來

A very common alternative to **burst into laughter**.

Practice 1

> I **burst out laughing** when I saw the photo.

我看到那張照片時突然**笑了出來**。

Practice 2

> She tried to stay serious but **burst out laughing**.

她努力保持嚴肅，但最後還是突然**笑了出來**。

MCQ-ready definition:

burst out laughing = 突然開始大笑

12. **burst out crying — 突然哭起來**

Practice 1

> He **burst out crying** after the argument.

爭吵後，他突然**哭了起來**。

Practice 2

> The little girl **burst out crying** when she lost her toy.

那個小女孩弄丟玩具後突然**哭了起來**。

MCQ-ready definition:

burst out crying = 突然開始哭泣

13. **burst out + words — 突然脫口而出**

Less common, but useful.

Practice 1

> “I can't believe it!” she **burst out**.

「我真不敢相信！」她突然**脫口而出**。

Practice 2

> He **burst out** that he had known the truth all along.

他突然**脫口說出**自己早就知道真相。

MCQ-ready definition:

burst out = 突然以強烈情緒說出某些話

14. **be bursting with emotion — 充滿強烈情緒**

Practice 1

> She was **bursting with excitement** before the trip.

旅行前，她**興奮得不得了**。

Practice 2

> He was **bursting with pride** after seeing his son's performance.

看到兒子的表現後，他**滿心自豪**。

MCQ-ready definition:

be bursting with + emotion = 某種情緒非常強烈，彷彿多得要滿溢出來

15. **burst with pride** — 充滿自豪；非常自豪

Practice 1

> His parents were **bursting with pride**.

他的父母**自豪極了**。

Practice 2

> She nearly **burst with pride** when she received the award.

她獲獎時簡直**自豪得不得了**。

MCQ-ready definition:

burst with pride = 感到極度自豪

16. **burst with excitement/joy** — 興奮 / 高興得不得了

Practice 1

> The children were **bursting with excitement**.

孩子們**興奮得不得了**。

Practice 2

> She looked as if she might **burst with joy**.

她看起來簡直**高興得快要爆開似的**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****burst with excitement/joy = 強烈地感到興奮或喜悅****

17. ****bursting to do something — 非常渴望做某事****

Informal.

Practice 1

> I'm ****bursting to tell you the news****.

我**急不及待想告訴你這個消息**。

Practice 2

> She was ****bursting to ask**** what had happened.

她**非常想問**到底發生了甚麼事。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****be bursting to do something = 非常急切、極想立刻做某件事****

18. ****bursting for the toilet / bursting to go — 急得不得了，要上廁所****

Informal, especially BrE.

Practice 1

> I'm ****bursting for the toilet****.

我**急得不得了，要上廁所**。

Practice 2

> The child said he was ****bursting to go****.

那個孩子說他**很急，要去洗手間**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****be bursting for/to go = 非常急着要上廁所****

****Register:** informal, especially British English.**

19. ****bursting at the seams — 擠得滿滿的；爆滿****

Originally refers to clothing or containers being so full that the seams seem about to burst.

Practice 1

> The hall was ****bursting at the seams****.

大廳****擠得水泄不通****。

Practice 2

> The suitcase was ****bursting at the seams****.

行李箱****塞得滿滿的，幾乎要爆開****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****bursting at the seams = 塞得或擠得非常滿，幾乎沒有空間****

20. ****a burst (突然的一下 / 一陣) — 突然爆發；一陣****

As a noun, ****burst**** often means something that happens suddenly and briefly.

Practice 1

> There was a sudden ****burst of laughter****.

突然傳來****一陣笑聲****。

Practice 2

> We heard a short ****burst of applause****.

我們聽到短短****一陣掌聲****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****a burst of something = 某件事突然、強烈而短暫地發生的一陣****

21. **a burst of laughter — 一陣突然的笑聲**

Practice 1

> A **burst of laughter** came from the next room.

隔壁房間傳來**一陣突然的笑聲**。

Practice 2

> His comment caused a **burst of laughter**.

他的話引起了**一陣大笑**。

MCQ-ready definition:

a burst of laughter = 突然出現的一陣笑聲

22. **a burst of applause — 一陣熱烈掌聲**

Practice 1

> Her speech ended with a **burst of applause**.

她的演講以**一陣熱烈掌聲**結束。

Practice 2

> A **burst of applause** greeted the winner.

勝出者受到**一陣掌聲**歡迎。

MCQ-ready definition:

a burst of applause = 突然響起的一陣掌聲

23. **a burst of speed — 突然加速；一陣高速**

Practice 1

> The runner produced a final **burst of speed**.

那名跑手最後突然**加速衝刺**。

Practice 2

> With a sudden **burst of speed**, the car overtook us.

那輛車突然**加速**，超越了我們。

MCQ-ready definition:

a burst of speed = 短時間內突然出現的高速或加速

24. **a burst of energy — 突然的一股精力**

Practice 1

> I had a sudden **burst of energy** after lunch.

午飯後我突然有了**一股精力**。

Practice 2

> The children had one last **burst of energy** before bedtime.

孩子們睡前又突然**精神大振了一陣**。

MCQ-ready definition:

a burst of energy = 短時間內突然增加的一股精力或活力

25. **a burst of activity — 一陣突然的忙碌 / 活動**

Practice 1

> The office experienced a **burst of activity** before the deadline.

限期前，辦公室突然出現**一陣忙碌**。

Practice 2

> After weeks of quiet, there was a sudden **burst of activity**.

幾星期的平靜後，突然出現**一陣活躍活動**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****a burst of activity = 短時間內突然出現的大量活動****

26. ****a burst of light — 一閃強光；突然出現的光****

Practice 1

> A bright ****burst of light**** filled the room.

一道突然出現的****強光****照滿了房間。

Practice 2

> We saw a brief ****burst of light**** in the sky.

我們看到天空中突然出現****一閃亮光****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****a burst of light = 突然出現而通常持續時間很短的強光****

27. ****burst someone's bubble — 打破某人的美好幻想****

A common idiom.

Practice 1

> I hate to ****burst your bubble****, but the tickets are already sold out.

我不想****打破你的幻想****，但門票已經售罄了。

Practice 2

> The poor results ****burst his bubble****.

差劣的結果****打破了他的美好幻想****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****burst someone's bubble = 令某人原本樂觀、美好的想法或幻想突然破滅****

28. ****a bubble bursts (figurative) — 泡沫破裂****

Common in economics and markets.

Practice 1

> The housing **bubble burst**.

房地產**泡沫破裂**了。

Practice 2

> Investors lost heavily when the technology **bubble burst**.

科技**泡沫爆破**時，投資者損失慘重。

MCQ-ready definition:

a bubble bursts = 過度膨脹的價格、投機或繁榮突然崩潰

29. **burst your buttons / be bursting out of clothes** — 衣服緊得快爆開

Literal-hyperbolic usage.

Practice 1

> The shirt was so tight that the buttons looked ready to **burst**.

那件恤衫太緊，鈕扣看起來快要**爆開**了。

Practice 2

> The bag was so full it looked ready to **burst**.

袋子塞得太滿，看起來快要**爆開**。

MCQ-ready definition:

burst = 因內部壓力或裝得太滿而突然裂開

Important distinction 1: **burst vs break**

Both can involve physical damage, but:

burst

typically suggests **internal pressure or sudden force causing something to split open**.

> The balloon **burst**.

氣球爆了。

break

much broader.

> The chair **broke**.

椅子壞了。

So:

* balloon → **burst** is very natural

* chair → **break** is natural

* pipe → either **burst** or **break**, but **burst** emphasizes pressure and rupture

Important distinction 2: **burst vs explode**

burst

usually means something suddenly splits open.

explode

usually involves a violent release of energy, often with heat, noise, gas, or destructive force.

> The balloon **burst**.

氣球爆了。

> The bomb **exploded**.

炸彈爆炸了。

A balloon normally **bursts**, while a bomb normally **explodes**.

Important distinction 3: **burst vs pop**

pop

often describes a small, sharp bursting sound and is more informal.

> The balloon **popped**.

氣球「啪」一聲爆了。

burst

is broader and somewhat more neutral.

> The balloon **burst**.

氣球爆了。

Both are natural for balloons.

Important distinction 4: **burst into tears vs start crying**

start crying

neutral:

> He **started crying**.

他開始哭。

burst into tears

adds:

- * suddenness

- * strong emotion

- * often more dramatic crying

> He **burst into tears**.

他突然哭了起來。

So **burst into tears** is more vivid.

Important distinction 5: **burst into tears** vs **break down in tears**

burst into tears

focuses on the **sudden beginning of crying**.

break down in tears

focuses more on **losing emotional control**.

> She **burst into tears**.

她突然哭起來。

> She **broke down in tears**.

她情緒崩潰，哭了起來。

The second is usually emotionally heavier.

Important distinction 6: **burst into laughter** vs **burst out laughing**

These mean essentially the same thing:

* **burst into laughter**

* **burst out laughing**

Both:

突然大笑起來

But the grammar differs:

burst into + noun

* tears

* laughter

* applause

* song

burst out + -ing

* laughing

* crying

Important distinction 7: **burst into tears vs burst out crying**

Again, meanings are extremely close.

> She **burst into tears**.

> She **burst out crying**.

Both mean:

**她突然哭了起來。 **

For learner purposes, **burst into tears** is especially useful and conventional.

Important distinction 8: **burst into a room vs burst into tears**

Same form, very different structure.

Place

> He **burst into the room**.

他突然闖進房間。

Here:

into + place

Sudden action/state

> He **burst into tears**.

他突然哭了起來。

Here:

into + event/state noun

So learners should not assume every **burst into** means 「闖入」.

Important distinction 9: **burst out laughing** vs **burst out of somewhere**

burst out laughing

= suddenly start laughing

burst out of the room

= suddenly rush out of the room

The word after **out** changes the structure completely.

Important distinction 10: **burst with** vs **full of**

full of excitement

= very excited / containing much excitement

bursting with excitement

= extremely excited, with a vivid sense that the emotion is almost too much to contain

So **bursting with** is more expressive and emphatic.

Important distinction 11: **a burst of energy** vs **energy**

energy

general state or amount of energy.

a burst of energy

a **short, sudden increase**.

> I have plenty of **energy** today.

我今天很有精神。

> I suddenly had a **burst of energy**.

我突然精神大振了一陣。

Important distinction 12: **burst** vs **bursting**

burst

verb/noun:

> The pipe **burst**.

水管爆裂了。

> a **burst** of laughter

一陣笑聲

bursting

participle/adjectival form:

> She was **bursting with excitement**.

她興奮極了。

Important distinction 13: **past tense of burst**

This is important because **burst** does **not** change in the past tense.

* present: **burst**

* past: **burst**

* past participle: **burst**

> The balloon **burst** yesterday.

氣球昨天爆了。

Not:

>  bursted

in standard modern English.

Family-extension note

****Burst**** has a strong and coherent semantic pattern built around:

**something suddenly breaks out, opens, begins, or appears with force**

From the literal physical sense:

****a balloon bursts****

English develops several highly productive figurative branches:

1. ****sudden emotional reaction****

- * burst into tears
- * burst into laughter
- * burst out laughing

2. ****sudden forceful movement****

- * burst into the room
- * burst through the door

3. ****being extremely full****

- * bursting with pride
- * bursting with excitement
- * bursting at the seams

4. ****a short, sudden episode****

- * a burst of energy
- * a burst of speed
- * a burst of applause

These are related enough that we should not pretend they are dozens of unrelated meanings, but they are distinct enough in grammar and usage to deserve separate learner-facing treatment.

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea	
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balloon bursts	氣球爆裂	split suddenly	
burst a balloon	弄爆氣球	cause rupture	
burst open	突然爆開 / 猛然打開	open suddenly	
burst into a room	突然闖進房間	forceful entry	
burst in	突然闖進來	sudden entrance	
burst through	衝破；穿過	force through	
burst into tears	突然哭起來	sudden crying	
burst into laughter	突然大笑	sudden laughter	
burst into applause	突然熱烈鼓掌	sudden applause	
burst into song	突然唱起歌	sudden singing	
burst out laughing	突然笑出來	sudden laughter	
burst out crying	突然哭起來	sudden crying	
burst out (speech)	脫口而出	sudden speech	
bursting with pride	自豪極了	emotion overflowing	
bursting with excitement	興奮極了	extreme excitement	
bursting to do X	急不及待想做 X	strong eagerness	
bursting at the seams	擠得 / 塞得滿滿的	excessively full	
a burst of laughter	一陣笑聲	sudden short episode	
a burst of applause	一陣掌聲	sudden applause	
a burst of speed	突然加速	short acceleration	
a burst of energy	一股突然的精力	short energy increase	
a burst of activity	一陣活動 / 忙碌	short intense activity	
a burst of light	一閃強光	sudden light	
burst someone's bubble	打破某人的幻想	destroy optimistic illusion	
bubble bursts	泡沫破裂	figurative collapse	

For your original sentence

> I thought he would **burst into tears**, but instead he just smiled and said, "That's okay, we can build a better one."

Here:

burst into tears = 突然哭起來；放聲哭起來

The expression emphasizes a **sudden emotional reaction**.

The semantic image is:

something physically bursts open suddenly

→ **an emotion suddenly breaks out**

→ **burst into tears**

So the speaker expected Leo to react strongly because his cardboard bridge had been broken.

But the contrast is important:

> he did ****not**** burst into tears

> instead, he smiled and calmly suggested building a better one.

That contrast helps show Leo's generosity and emotional resilience.